FLUTTERBY FIELD SCHOOL · COURSE PITCH FOR PENINSULA BRIDGE

Why teach AI thinking to 6th graders?

A joyful, high-energy curriculum where students learn how "smart" systems really work — using birds and ecology as the playground.

Artificial intelligence already shapes homework help, social media, hiring tools, and the Bay Area economy. Yet students from first-generation and low-income backgrounds are far less likely to get early, hands-on exposure to what AI *is* — and what it gets wrong. Without that foundation, they risk becoming permanent **users** of powerful systems instead of informed **questioners, creators, and leaders**.

> **Our goal:** Increase diversity and inclusion in the AI-powered future by teaching AI literacy early — through play, movement, and clear thinking — so every Peninsula Bridge scholar can understand patterns, challenge biased results, and speak with evidence.

WHY THIS COURSE

Flutterby Field School leads with AI concepts sixth graders can actually grasp: *a computer only follows the rules we give it*, *bad data makes bad predictions*, and *humans must stay in the loop*. Birds and ecology make those ideas concrete and fun — beak races, food-web tug-of-war, and simple "teach the robot" games — without coding, expensive labs, or heavy jargon.

What students practice

- Spot patterns and write simple rules
- Test a rule, then break it on purpose
- Explain when data (or AI) misleads
- Argue from evidence, not guesses

Why birds?

- High-energy labs kids remember
- Real science in their own backyard
- A friendly on-ramp to STEM identity
- Data they create themselves → "AI"

THE PENINSULA BRIDGE CONNECTION

Peninsula Bridge empowers highly motivated, first-gen, low-income students toward college and career success. This course fits that continuum: it builds academic confidence, STEM belonging, and future-ready AI awareness in middle school — before pathways narrow. Scholars leave not only knowing more about living systems, but believing **"I can understand the technology that will shape my future."**

DESIGNED FOR ENERGETIC 6TH GRADERS

Short, active lessons teachers can run with simple materials. Priority experiences: bird-beak challenges and food-web games, paired with one clear AI hook each day. Optional capstone: a simple conservation trade-off sim (FlockQuest) for debate with numbers.

Flutterby Field School · Grades 5–8 (tuned for 6th) · Live materials: https://kapurhope.github.io/flutterby/bird-curriculum/